THE WHOLE STORY · SMALL GROUP GUIDE · LESSON 26 OF 26

Revelation and the New Creation

Revelation 1; 4–5; 21–22

The big idea: Revelation pulls back the curtain. The risen Jesus holds the keys of death, the throne of heaven is not empty, and the Lion of Judah conquers as the Lamb who was slain. Evil is judged, and the story ends where it began: heaven and earth, a river, and the tree of life. God dwells with his people, they see his face, and the Bible's last word is an invitation: Come.

Before you meet: Read

Revelation 1:9–18 | Revelation 5:1–14 | Revelation 7:9–17 | Revelation 21:1–8 | Revelation 22:1–5, 17, 20–21

Open (5 minutes)

What is the best ending to a story, book, or movie you know? What made it satisfying?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am _____ forevermore." *(Revelation 1:17–18)*

"Worthy is the _____ who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!" *(Revelation 5:12)*

"Behold, the dwelling place of God is with _____. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people." *(Revelation 21:3)*

"He will wipe away every _____ from their eyes, and death shall be no more." *(Revelation 21:4)*

"Behold, I am making all things _____." *(Revelation 21:5)*

"Let the one who desires take the water of life without _____." *(Revelation 22:17)*

Discuss

1. What did you think Revelation was about before this lesson? What surprised you? *Revelation 1:1–3*

2. Why did John need to see the risen Jesus before he saw anything else? *Revelation 1:12–18*

3. The Lion conquers as the Lamb. What does that tell us about how God wins? *Revelation 5:5–10*

4. How should the reality of final judgment shape the way we live and speak to others? *Revelation 20:11–15; 22:17*

5. Heaven comes down to earth in Revelation 21. How is that different from what most people imagine? *Revelation 21:1–5; Romans 8:19–21*

6. Looking back over all twenty-six lessons, what is the most important thing you have learned about God's story? *Luke 24:27; Revelation 22:1–4*

Apply this week

Read Revelation 1, 4–5, and 21–22 aloud this week. Pray Revelation 5:12 back to God each day. Bring one sorrow to God and read Revelation 21:4 over it. Invite one person to read the Bible with you or come to church with you.

Memory verse

"Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God."

Revelation 21:3

Pray

Worship the Lamb who was slain and now reigns. Thank God that he will wipe away every tear and make all things new. Pray for anyone you know who has not yet come to Christ, and end with the church's oldest prayer: Come, Lord Jesus.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 26

Revelation and the New Creation

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Revelation 5:1–14 aloud together. Then read Revelation 21:1–5.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
25 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 3, 4, and 6 matter most.
10 min	Walk the group through The Bookends of the Bible and The Whole Story in Six Acts in the full lesson. Let each person name one moment from the series that stayed with them.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse, celebrate finishing the series, and agree on what the group will read next.

Main points to land

1. Revelation unveils Jesus Christ: the risen Lord who holds the keys of Death and Hades and walks among his churches (Revelation 1:1, 17–18).
2. The Lion of Judah conquers as the Lamb who was slain, and by his blood he ransoms people from every nation (Revelation 5:5–10; 7:9–14).
3. Evil is loud but losing. Christ returns as King of kings, and every person will stand before God's judgment (Revelation 19:11–16; 20:11–15; WCF 33).
4. God will make all things new and dwell with his people; there will be no more death, tears, or curse, and they will see his face (Revelation 21:1–5; 22:1–4).
5. The Bible ends with an invitation: whoever is thirsty may come and take the water of life without price (Revelation 22:17).

Core doctrine to teach

Christ's Return and the New Creation CORE DOCTRINE 26 OF 26

Jesus will return bodily and visibly in glory. He will raise the dead, judge the world in righteousness, and make all things new. Those who belong to him will live forever with God in a renewed creation, and those who refuse him will face his just judgment. *Acts 1:11; 17:31; 1 Thessalonians 4:16–17; Revelation 21:1–5*

Answer key (Observe)

1. alive
2. Lamb
3. man
4. tear
5. new

6. price

Questions people will ask

Why do Christians disagree so much about Revelation?
Revelation uses symbols drawn from the Old Testament, and faithful Christians read the timing of its visions differently. But they agree on the main message: Jesus reigns, he will return bodily, evil will be judged, and God will make all things new. Hold the details humbly and the main message firmly.

Will Christians float on clouds forever?
No. When believers die, their souls go to be with Christ, but the Bible's final hope is resurrection bodies on a new earth (Revelation 21:1–3; 1 Corinthians 15:42–44). Heaven comes down. We will live, work, and worship in a renewed creation, with God dwelling among us.

How can a loving God judge people in a lake of fire?
Because God is holy and just, evil cannot be ignored forever, and a God who never judged would not be good. Revelation 20 is sobering. But the same book offers the water of life without price to anyone who is thirsty (Revelation 22:17). The Lamb was slain so that sinners can be saved.

When will Jesus return?
No one knows the day or the hour (Matthew 24:36), so date-setting is foolish. What we know is that he is coming, and that should make us ready, watchful, and eager to tell others. The church's prayer is Come, Lord Jesus (Revelation 22:20).

Closing prayer

Lord Jesus, you are the first and the last, the Lamb who was slain and now reigns. Thank you for walking us through your whole story. Keep us faithful until you come, make us eager to say Come to the thirsty, and bring us home to the city where we will see your face. Come, Lord Jesus. Amen.